

Now, of course, you can't expect heavy titles to work flawlessly here. There are better laptops for that kind of stuff, and the Neo doesn't even come close, let alone being a proper competitor. But for light gaming and stuff, it holds up decently well.

I played *Shadow of the Tomb Raider*, *Overcooked 2* and *Hollow Knight* Silksong on the device and the overall experience was better than expected.

I will put this out again. The MacBook Neo is not a gaming laptop, nor is macOS designed in a way like the Windows platform to take advantage of high-end games. That said, for the light kind of stuff, the things that the laptop supports, a casual gamer will deal with this machine just fine.

Apart from this, in terms of the day to day performance, the A18 Pro chip holds up pretty well. For normal workloads, it does its job as expected.

In fact, at one point, I had around 20 Chrome tabs open alongside multiple apps, and the system showed no signs of slowing down. Moreover, I also switched from Steam to Google Chrome (with a game running in the background) and the MacBook Neo didn't appear to be stressed at all. In addition to this, app launches are quick and switching between is a breeze.

In raw numbers too, the MacBook Neo does a decent job. In the Geekbench CPU benchmark, it outperformed the M3 MacBook Air 15-inch in the single-core test. The M3 MacBook Air scores 2980 points while the Neo scores 3406 points. It performed respectfully across other benchmarks as well.

Two things that deserve special mention are the laptop's speakers and webcam. For me, these two were the unexpected highlights. The laptop comes with a 1080p camera and it shines with all its glory during video calls. It made me look sharp and clear while I was attending virtual meetings and honestly, I loved the overall appeal.

As for the audio, the MacBook Neo comes with dual side-firing speakers that do their job well. Even while



playing *Hollow Knight* in a busy office environment, I could easily hear in-game audio without feeling like the speakers were struggling. The sound quality was also crisp and clear, with the right amount of bass.

Apart from gaming and my usual work, I also edited a birthday-special video for my sister on the device. I edited the entire 15-minute video using Final Cut Pro and it was smooth sailing throughout. So you can also use the Neo for some light video editing on the go.

BATTERY AND THERMALS

With the MacBook Neo, Apple promised a battery life of 11 hours of wireless web browsing. And it indeed is true. I logged in to work at 8 am sharp and used the MacBook Neo at 50 per cent brightness for 9 hours. When I was about to leave for home, the laptop still had 20 per cent battery left.

During this time, I used Google Docs, 10-15 Google Chrome tabs, and even watched a video or two. I never turned the laptop to low power mode or low brightness. With these two enabled, the laptop can go up to 10-11 hours as well.

When you talk about charging, it takes roughly 4 hours to charge the device, as it ships with a 20W adapter.

The Neo also comes with a fan-less design like the MacBook Air. And yet, you won't feel it getting too hot to handle. While I was running benchmark tests, the surface temperatures never rose above 29.2 degrees Celsius. The touchpad remained even cooler, at 27 degrees. Even while gaming, the surface temperatures stayed within limits.

SHOULD YOU BUY THE APPLE MACBOOK NEO?

The MacBook Neo delivers the core Mac experience at a price point that is new for Apple. Thus, it is the best way to experience macOS, better even than the Mac mini, if you aren't willing to spend around Rs 1 lakh on a new device. The laptop also boasts a relatively strong day to day performance, excellent battery life, reliable display, and a design that lives up to Apple's reputation.

With that being said, there are also certain compromises that include the non-backlit keyboard, absence of touch ID in the base variant and only having an 8 GB RAM option, raising a question in terms of future-proofing. However, for students, first-time Mac users, or anyone looking for a reliable laptop in this budget, the Neo makes a very solid case for itself. It gets the essentials right and comes with Apple's reliability. And for some people, that's enough.

—Divyanshi Sharma

SPECIFICATIONS

Processor: Apple A18 Pro | Memory: 8 GB Unified | Storage: 256/512 GB | Display: 13-inch LED-backlit IPS display | Brightness: 500 nits | Refresh rate: 60 Hz | Battery: 36.5 WHr Li-ion | Charging: 20W USB-C | Ports: 1x USB 3 (Type-C), 1x USB 2 (Type-C), 1x 3.5 mm headphone jack

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